

Cultural Dialogue between Iran and the Subcontinent: Spirituality and Sufism

Sufi Poetry: a vehicle of strong bonding between Iran and the Subcontinent

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The search for inner spirituality through a heightened spiritual experience has been a fundamental aspect of all living religions of the world. Sufism in Islam represents this quest for inner spirituality. Sufism traces back its foundations to the simple and ascetic lifestyle of Prophet Muhammad and the divine word as revealed in the Quran. These two sources inspired the development of Sufism in the mediaeval period of Islam. Some of the Prophet's venerated companions, including Ali ibn Abi Talib, Abu Dharr al-Ghafari, Salman Farsi, and Uwais al-Qarani are among the spiritual ancestors of Sufism³. The resistant but ascetic attitude of Muslim circles laid the foundation of Sufism in the late seventh and early eighth centuries. Following its noticeable appearance under the Umayyads the Sufi thought was further developed by Sufi saints, Imams and scholars under the Abbasids. Hasan al-Basri and Imam Jafar as-Sadiq are regarded as the two greatest teachers of Sufism. It began in Medina but blossomed in Iraq, Syria, Egypt, Persia, the subcontinent, Afghanistan and Central Asia. Sufism is a major discipline within Islam characterized by love and devotion for God, Prophet Muhammad and his family and the principles of humanity and tolerance.

The spiritual atmosphere created by the Sufi poetry is central to the spiritual life in Islam. First composed in classical languages – Arabic and Persian – the Sufi verse is written in almost all the languages of the subcontinent. The famous forms of Sufi poetry in Persian and South Asian languages include *munajaat* or *munqabat*, *qasida*, *ghazal*, *ruba'i*, *masnawi*, *marsiya*, *kafi*, *ginan*, *bara mah*, *athvara* and *siharfi*. This paper presents a brief account of the development of Sufi verse in Persian and the languages of the subcontinent. It provides a brief sketch of the great classical Sufi poets in Persian and South Asia languages whose compositions have touched the lives of millions in Iran, Afghanistan and the subcontinent. The paper elucidates the strong influence of Persian on literary forms and genres of mystic poetry in the subcontinent. The Persian poetic tradition followed in the indigenous languages of the subcontinent is the vehicle to bring the people of Iran and the subcontinent together and create a lasting relationship.

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³ Schimmel, Annemarie. 1975. *Mystical Dimensions of Islam*. Lahore: Sang-e-Meel Publications [Reprint 2003].